

4 Text properties

Arguably the most important element of any page is the text on it. The text represents the content you are portraying through your website. Often, all the effort in styling goes into some incredibly beautiful masthead, logo, or background, and making the top of the web page look great, but scroll down to the actual content you might encounter a CSS famine.

The first thing that appears when a page is loading is the text on it, and the presentation of text has the power to convey to the user if the website is serious or friendly, modern or traditional, formal or casual. Choosing the right font or a combination of fonts is important in creating the right first impression.

The first thing you should generally do is override some of the browser's default CSS properties, specifically the typeface and the font size. This is fairly straightforward, but there are a few issues you should be aware of. The following properties are typically declared in the body selector, allowing all the following elements to inherit the values. Further customization can be done to individual elements if required.

4.1 font-family

The font-family property declares a list of font family names and/or generic family names for the element, in a priority order. The browser will use the first available font on the end user's machine. There are two types of font-family values:

Family name: The name of a font family, like Times, Georgia, Arial, etc.

Generic family: The name of a generic family, like serif, sans-serif, cursive, fantasy, etc.

The values should be separated by a comma, and it is suggested that you use a generic family name as the final option in the list. If a family name contains whitespace it should be enclosed in quotes. For example the font Lucida Grande is written as "Lucida Grande". Note that single quotes need to be used if you are embedding the style in HTML.

In the example that follows we define the font-family for the body selector; this will ensure all the elements in the page will inherit the same font family unless declared specifically.